

POLICY BRIEF

Normalizing Security in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa: A 15-Year Roadmap

For federal and provincial decision-makers · Data cut-off: 4 October 2026

Audience: Federal Cabinet and National Security Committee; KP provincial government and Assembly; Ministry of Interior; KP Home Department and Police; NACTA; Finance Division and the National Finance Commission; international partners. **Data cut-off:** 4 October 2026. **Basis:** the accompanying 16-chapter research monograph.

1. The Problem in One Page

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa is in the fifth consecutive year of a rising insurgency. In 2025 the province recorded 2,331 violence-linked fatalities — the highest since 2015 and 44 per cent above 2024 — and Pakistan became the country most impacted by terrorism in the world (CRSS 2025b; IEP 2026). In the first half of 2026 alone, 122 police officers were killed (a 93.7 per cent year-on-year increase) and 680 attacks were recorded against police between January and September. On 26 February 2026, Pakistan opened an interstate front against the Afghan Taliban administration — Operation Ghazab-lil-Haq — after the collapse of the October 2025 Doha ceasefire and the November 2025 Istanbul monitoring mechanism. By late September 2026, UNAMA had recorded more than 1,100 civilian casualties in Afghanistan; two Eid ceasefires had failed; and the border had been closed for extended periods.

The insurgency is not a residual law-and-order problem. It is a networked coalition of more than seventy factions under the TTP umbrella (EUAA 2026), enabled by a rear base in Afghanistan, financed by extortion and war economies, and reproduced by a radicalization pipeline that runs faster than the state's rehabilitation programmes. And it is now embedded in an interstate conflict that imposes costs on both sides of the Durand Line.

Yet the study's central finding is that **the binding constraints on normalization are domestic and fiscal, not military**. The state's own unkept commitments — the fiscal settlement of the merged districts, the protection of the police who bear the casualties, and the availability of lawful political channels for Pashtun grievance — are the variables with the greatest causal weight and the least external dependency. This brief translates the monograph's findings into an implementation sequence, costs, and monitoring architecture for decision-makers.

The brief in ten lines. (1) Violence is rising for a fifth year and is now embedded in an interstate conflict. (2) Operations degrade but do not defeat the insurgency. (3) The 2018 merger is constitutionally complete and fiscally hollow: Rs 568 billion short. (4) The police absorb the casualties without the protection or resources to match. (5) Justice and local government are absent precisely where the conflict is fought. (6) Deradicalization is small, unevaluated and underfunded. (7) Exclusion of lawful political actors feeds recruitment. (8) The Afghanistan channel must be managed and verified, not wished away. (9) The roadmap costs Rs 150–250 billion a year against an annual conflict loss of Rs 400–800 billion. (10) Every binding constraint is domestic — and therefore actionable.

2. What the Evidence Shows: Eight Findings for Policymakers

2.1 Kinetic operations degrade but do not defeat. Rah-e-Rast (2009), Rah-e-Nijat (2009) and Zarb-e-Azb (2014–17) each reduced militant capacity; each was followed by recurrence. The monograph's seven-criteria assessment (military effect, civilian protection, displacement and return, governance restoration, justice, economic recovery, public perception) shows that operations succeed tactically and fail institutionally. The decay sequence — clearance, decline, complacency, regeneration, recurrence — shortens sharply when a sanctuary exists, as it has since 2021.

2.2 The sanctuary is the multiplier. The TTP's leadership, training, financing and family structures are in Afghanistan; the violence in KP's southern districts and merged areas is sustained from across the border. Force alone has not closed the sanctuary, and the 2026 war has not produced a settlement. What is achievable in the near term is a **verifiable management regime**: monitored commitments, prisoner exchanges, border trade and mobility arrangements, and institutionalized third-party mediation — not a comprehensive peace treaty.

2.3 The FATA merger's fiscal failure is the largest self-inflicted wound. Against the parliamentary commitment of 3 per cent of the divisible pool — roughly Rs 700 billion — only Rs 132 billion had reached the merged districts by mid-2026: a **Rs 568 billion shortfall**, with the commitment expiring in 2028 and no successor framework confirmed. This is not an accounting issue; it is the difference between an integration narrative and a betrayal narrative in the districts where the insurgency recruits.

2.4 Police are the front line and the weakest-protected link. More than 500 officers killed since 2023; 122 in the first half of 2026; CTD staffing 19 per cent below sanctioned strength; documented shortfalls in protected mobility, counter-IED and counter-drone equipment. The police hold the line on a provincial budget while policy is set federally — a structural mismatch that produces both casualties and blame-shifting (ICG 2026).

2.5 Justice is the missing institution. Anti-terrorism court pendency (2,273 cases nationally as of November 2024), weak investigation quality, witness intimidation, and the near-absence of functioning courts in the merged districts mean that the state's coercive actions are not converted into lawful outcomes. Impunity sustains both militancy (no deterrence) and

grievance (no justice).

2.6 Reintegration is under-resourced and unevaluated. Sabawoon's 226 juveniles (2009–2015, ~143 reintegrated, 10–15 relapses) are a fraction of demand; claims about Mishal and Sparlay are mutually inconsistent and no independent evaluation exists in seventeen years. The instruments are plausible — family-based rehabilitation, vocational aftercare, religious counter-narrative — but the programme architecture, law and funding are not.

2.7 Exclusion is counter-insurgency self-harm. The October 2024 proscription of the non-violent Pashtun Tahafuz Movement, the criminalisation of journalistic expression, and indefinite detention without charge have removed the lawful channels through which Pashtun grievance was expressed — the same grievance the insurgency recruits from. Restoring lawful political space is the cheapest security intervention available to the state.

2.8 The economics are decisive. KP's annual conflict-related loss is estimated at **Rs 400–800 billion**. The roadmap's incremental cost — **Rs 150–250 billion per year at maturity** plus the arrears — is a quarter to a half of that loss. Every year of delay is, on this arithmetic, more expensive than the entire reform programme.

3. The Strategic Shift: From Campaign to Compact

The monograph's "three monopolies" framework defines the objective: the state's **monopoly of organized violence**, the citizen's **enforceable claim on the state** (justice and governance), and the province's **claim on national resources** (fiscal federalism). Normalization is the construction of all three. A campaign addresses only the first; a compact addresses all three.

Monopoly	Current status (2026)	Required instrument
Violence	Contested; police over-matched; TTP taxation in parts of the NMDs	Protected, professional police; intelligence fusion; managed border regime
Justice/governance	Absent in the NMDs; ATC throughput failing; local government unelected	Courts, prosecutors, witness protection; elected councils with budgets
Resources	Rs 568 bn shortfall; commitment expiring 2028	Statutory transfer with audit; provincial fiscal compact

4. Phase I (0–2 Years): Stabilisation, Fiscal Rescue, Protection Pivot

4.1 Pay the arrears and legislate the transfer — the first 12 months

- 1. Legislate** the merged-district transfer: conclude the NFC award with a mandated floor; failing that, a presidential order under Article 160; failing that, a statutory federal grant — so the commitment survives the 2028 expiry. *Lead: Federal Finance/NFC/PMO.*
- 2. Clear the Rs 568 billion arrears** on a published schedule with quarterly milestones; publish district-wise releases monthly. *Lead: Federal Finance with KP Finance.*
- 3. Ring-fence and audit:** community monitoring committees in each district; public beneficiary lists for compensation; referral of diversion to anti-corruption bodies. *Lead: KP government; Auditor-General.*

4.2 Protect the police — the retention and credibility prerequisite

- 1. Emergency protection package:** mine-protected vehicles, counter-IED equipment and training, counter-drone systems for static posts, secure communications — deployed first to Kohat, Lakki Marwat, Bannu, D.I. Khan, Tank, Kurram, Khyber, and North/South Waziristan. *Lead: KP Police; Interior (supplementary grant); indicative cost Rs 50–80 bn one-off, Rs 30–50 bn/yr recurrent.*
- 2. Complete insurance and compensation** for officers and families; publish an annual shuhada report; make attack post-mortems mandatory and their aggregate findings public. *Lead: KP Police/Home.*
- 3. Accelerate recruitment** (including the 6,000+ posts announced in July 2026) with merged-district quotas and rehabilitation posts for the wounded.

4.3 Contain the external front

- 1. Convert the ceasefire cycles into a verified monitoring mechanism:** reciprocal commitments, prisoner exchanges, a border-management regime (documented mobility, trade facilitation), and a standing mediation format (China, Qatar, Türkiye, Saudi Arabia) with published quarterly status reports. *Lead: MOFA; Security Divisions.*
- 2. Lawful refugee processing:** individual, documented, appealable procedures for Afghan nationals; no mass refoulement; UNHCR verification of voluntary returns. *Lead: SAFRON/Interior; UNHCR.*

4.4 Restore legitimacy at low cost

1. **Lift the PTM proscription** and release detainees held without terrorism charges; open a lawful channel for Pashtun political demands. *Lead: Federal Cabinet/Interior.*
2. **End indefinite detention without charge**; publish detainee numbers; create a statutory juvenile track. *Lead: Interior/Home.*
3. **Resolve the criminalisation of journalism**: reform PECA's broad speech offences and investigate attacks on journalists. *Lead: Federal Interior; KP Home.*

4.5 No-regret measures for the first 90 days

Three actions require no new money and no legislation, and each raises the credibility of everything that follows:

1. **Publish the data.** Direct the Home Department and KP Police to publish quarterly, district-wise attack, casualty and compensation figures, and the Finance Department to publish monthly merged-district releases. Transparency is the cheapest accountability mechanism available.
2. **Audit the pipeline.** Convene the merged-district coordination forum (federal, provincial, district, Auditor-General) to reconcile every rupee committed against every rupee delivered since 2019, with a public reconciliation table.
3. **Fix the response to casualties.** Institute a standing protocol: every police fatality triggers a documented review within 14 days, automatic family-compensation processing within 30 days, and an equipment-needs assessment for the affected unit within 45 days.

5. Phase II (2–5 Years): Institutionalisation

5.1 Justice

1. **Judicial delivery plan for the merged districts**: appointed and funded judges, prosecutors, staff, court infrastructure, mobile courts and video links. *Lead: Law/PHC/Prosecution.*
2. **ATC throughput targets**: 75 per cent of cases concluded within 24 months; published quarterly data; witness-protection legislation with a funded unit. *Lead: Home/Prosecution.*
3. **Victims' reparations scheme**: compensation, psychosocial services, reconstruction, and a documented register of all victims, including of state operations. *Lead: KP government/Health.*
4. **Enforce the Kurram accords** with disarmament milestones and guarantees of road reopening; prosecute violations. *Lead: KP government; jirga oversight.*

5.2 Policing and intelligence

1. **Complete the merged-district policing framework**: finish the Levies/Khasadar integration, statutory police for all seven districts, a training academy in the merged districts, and staged transfer of primacy against capability milestones. *Lead: KP Home/Police.*
2. **Professionalise the CTD**: separate operation from investigation; analytical cadre; published arrest–charge–conviction data. Fund forensics and digital-evidence handling. *Lead: CTD/Home.*
3. **Joint counter-terrorism fusion centre** with legal authority, data-protection rules and parliamentary oversight. *Lead: Home/CTD/NACTA.*
4. **Fixed-tenure, merit-based police appointments** (IG, CCPO, DPO) to insulate leadership from political transfer cycles. *Lead: KP government.*
5. **NACTA reform**: professional civilian secretariat, statutory data access from provinces and agencies, and a public annual threat report. *Lead: Federal Interior/NACTA.*

5.3 Reintegration, madrasas and counter-narratives

1. **Enact a deradicalization and reintegration statute** creating a KP Rehabilitation and Reintegration Authority with admission criteria, judicial oversight and a ring-fenced budget. *Lead: KP Assembly/Home.*
2. **Relocate and expand capacity** to Bannu, D.I. Khan and the merged districts; family-based rehabilitation, aftercare grants, apprenticeships with chambers of commerce. *Lead: Home/CTD; chambers.*
3. **Mandate an independent five-year evaluation** of all programmes, with published recidivism and employment outcomes. *Lead: Planning & Development; donors/universities.*

4. **Restore a consultative madrasa registration framework** after the October 2024 reversal, with transparency conditions, modern-subject funding, and separation of registration from security surveillance. *Lead: Federal ITE; provinces.*
5. **Fund Pashto-language counter-narrative content** produced by local scholars, women's groups and former combatants. *Lead: Information/CTD/NGOs.*

5.4 Local government and accountability

1. **Hold local government elections in the merged districts** with devolved budgets and own-source revenue; ring-fence a share of the merged-district fund for district councils. *Lead: KP Local Government/ECP.*
2. **Enact a statutory federal–provincial security compact** defining financing, roles and joint reporting — ending the mismatch in which the province fights a national campaign on provincial resources. *Lead: Federal/Provincial.*
3. **Institutionalise the annual Normalization Report** with an independent technical panel, a non-compliance register, and tabling in the KP Assembly. *Lead: P&D; KP Assembly.*
4. **Anti-corruption in merged-district contracts and funds** (minerals, land, construction) with published audits and recoveries. *Lead: ACE/NAB/KPPRA.*

5.5 The generational bet

1. **Education emergency in the merged districts:** girls' enrolment (currently ~37 per cent primary, ~5 per cent secondary), female teachers, secure campuses and transport, stipends. *Lead: Education Department; donors; indicative cost Rs 40–60 bn/yr.*
2. **Youth employment pipeline:** skills, SEZs (Rashakai), IT/freelancing hubs, tourism value chains, apprenticeships. *Lead: P&D/Industries.*
3. **Climate-resilient reconstruction** and GLOF early warning (2025 floods: 504 deaths, 1.57 million affected in KP). *Lead: PDMA/FDMA.*

6. Phase III (5–15 Years): Consolidation

1. **Community security contracts:** district-level, co-designed security plans with published targets, linking councils, police and jirgas.
2. **Truth and documentation:** a legally established provincial process to document the conflict's human cost on all sides, identify the missing, and publish a public record — paired with selective accountability for mass-casualty atrocities.
3. **Regional normalization:** trade, mobility and people-to-people ties with Afghanistan; SCO/OIC counter-terrorism cooperation; a settled border regime ratified on both sides.
4. **Economic transformation:** minerals with local value addition, hydropower, tourism (12.4 million visitors in 2025), IT exports, agriculture — with the merged-district poverty gap closed to within ten points of the provincial average.
5. **Verified negotiation framework with the TTP,** if and when available on the comparative criteria: decentralized, conditional, verified, staged, monitored decommissioning, and explicit no-impunity boundaries.

7. Financing

Instrument	Indicative scale	Source
Merged-district arrears	Rs 568 bn (stock)	Federal revenue; reallocation
Statutory merged-district transfer	~Rs 192 bn/yr (3% framework)	NFC/divisible pool; protected in budget
Police protection package	Rs 50–80 bn one-off; Rs 30–50 bn/yr	Federal supplementary grant; provincial budget
Justice expansion	Rs 5–10 bn/yr	Provincial + federal
Reintegration and deradicalization	Rs 10–20 bn/yr	Provincial + donors
Education emergency (NMDs)	Rs 40–60 bn/yr	Provincial + donors
Local government and M&E	Rs 5–10 bn/yr	Merged-district allocation

Aggregate incremental requirement: Rs 150–250 bn per year at maturity, against an estimated annual conflict loss of Rs 400–800 bn. Financing principles: ring-fence allocations from budget lapse; publish district-wise releases; fund recurrent costs (teachers, police, judges) not only construction; condition donor tranches on verified delivery; treat compensation as an automatic entitlement, not patronage.

7.1 Why the arithmetic is politically feasible

The financing requirement is often framed as unaffordable. The comparison is instructive: the merged-district shortfall (Rs 568 billion) is roughly equivalent to **three months of the estimated annual security and economic cost of the conflict** at the midpoint of the loss estimate; the protection package for the police (Rs 50–80 billion) is under 5 per cent of annual provincial conflict losses; and the education emergency in the merged districts (Rs 40–60 billion per year) costs less than a single week of national conflict losses at the higher end of the estimate. In fiscal terms, Pakistan cannot afford *not* to fund the roadmap: the conflict consumes the resources that the state then borrows to replace.

8. Monitoring and Evaluation

The monograph operationalises the three deficits into measurable commitments: **fiscal** (release rates, arrears, audit follow-up, compensation timeliness); **accountability** (police attacks and deaths, arrest–charge–conviction progression, ATC conclusions, misconduct investigations, prison incidents, CFT seizures); and **legitimacy** (local elections, detainees held without charge, prosecutions for expression, trust surveys, return and restitution rates). Six security-consolidation indicators — conflict fatalities by district, TTP taxation reports, school attacks, border-closure days, drone attacks thwarted, and attacks on health and minority targets — provide the early-warning layer. The architecture is a small monitoring cell in the Planning and Development Department, an independent panel, and an **Annual Normalization Report tabled in the KP Assembly within 180 days of each fiscal year**, including a non-compliance register naming responsible institutions.

8.1 Institutional responsibilities at a glance

Function	Federal	Provincial	District/Local	Partners
Merged-district fund and audit	Finance, NFC, PMO	KP Finance	Community committees	Auditor-General
Police protection and compensation	Interior (supplementary)	Home, Police	DPOs	Donors (equipment)
CTD, fusion centre, CFT	Interior, NACTA	Home, CTD	—	FATF-consistent partners
Border and mediation	MOFA, Security Divisions	Border districts	Levies/police	China, Qatar, Türkiye, Saudi Arabia
Refugee processing	SAFRON, Interior	KP administration	Transit centres	UNHCR, IOM
Deradicalization and reintegration	NACTA, Interior	Home, CTD	DRCs	Universities, NGOs
Courts and ATCs	Law, Supreme Court	Prosecution, PHC	District judiciary	UNODC, partners
Local government	ECP, Law	Local Government	Councils	UNDP, donors
Education, health, employment	Federal schemes	Line departments	DEOs, facilities	UNICEF, WFP, World Bank
Monitoring and annual report	Planning	P&D cell	District statistics	Independent panel

9. Risks and Mitigations

Risk	Mitigation
Fiscal promises again deferred past 2028	Statute, not discretion; audited annual reporting; election-cycle accountability
Elite capture of merged-district funds	Community monitoring, public beneficiary lists, asset recovery, elected councils
TTP spoilers attack visible successes	Protect schools, markets, SEZ and tourism routes; rapid compensation; narrative management
Casualties erode police recruitment and morale	Protection-first sequencing; insurance; recruitment; family support
Political instability/elections interrupt reform	Multi-year budgeting; provincial security charter; independent monitoring
External escalation with Afghanistan	Standing mediation mechanism; diversified trade routes; contingency planning
Surveillance expansion erodes rights	Data-protection statute and parliamentary oversight <i>before</i> Safe City expansion

10. Priority Actions — First 24 Months

1. Legislate the merged-district transfer and publish a schedule to clear arrears (Federal Finance/PMO).
2. Fund and deploy the police protection package to the highest-casualty districts (KP Police/Interior).
3. Complete police insurance/compensation and publish the shuhada report (KP Police/Home).
4. Convert the ceasefire into a verified monitoring mechanism with standing mediation (MOFA).
5. Lift the PTM proscription and release detainees without terrorism charges (Federal Cabinet).
6. Institutionalise post-operation collateral-harm review and rapid compensation (Army/CTD).
7. Lawful, appealable refugee processing with UNHCR access (SAFRON/Interior).
8. Publish the first Annual Normalization Report within 12 months (P&D/KP Assembly).

11. Comparative Lessons That Shaped This Roadmap

The monograph's structured comparison of eight conflict transitions yields a consistent architecture — political framework + security-sector reform + economic dividend + legitimacy mechanisms, sustained over a decade or more, with independent monitoring. The most transferable elements:

Case	Transferable lesson	Application in KP
Northern Ireland	Police reform (Patten Commission) is the load-bearing wall of normalization	Rights-based training, representative recruitment, independent oversight of a reformed KP Police; community policing in the NMDs
Colombia (FARC)	Reintegration fails without security guarantees and economic protection for ex-combatants	Protect rehabilitees from retaliation; fund aftercare, apprenticeships and employer partnerships
Mindanao / BARMM	Autonomy with real fiscal transfers plus third-party monitoring sustains settlements	Statutory merged-district fund with independent monitoring of both fiscal and security commitments
Sierra Leone	Hybrid justice (truth process plus selective accountability) can consolidate a fragile peace	Provincial documentation process for the conflict's human cost, with targeted prosecutions for mass-casualty atrocities
Sri Lanka	Military victory without political settlement does not normalize	Warns against a purely kinetic endgame: even a degraded TTP would not normalize Swat, the NMDs or Kurram absent political and fiscal delivery
Iraqi Kurdistan	Party-fragmented security forces entrench instability; fiscal dependence is dangerous	Avoid a party/patronage-based NMD police; ring-fence transfers from political bargaining
Chechnya/Dagestan (critical)	Extreme coercion suppresses violence while destroying the rule of law and exporting the conflict	A model to be rejected: it would require dismantling Pakistan's constitutional order and would leave recruitment narratives intact
Afghanistan (2001–2021)	Security forces cannot be rented; corruption and exclusion hand the insurgency its strongest argument	Build the police and courts as indigenous, legitimate institutions; treat corruption as counter-insurgency policy

The synthesis: no single case supplies a template; the workable pathway is a hybrid — Northern Ireland's policing and inclusion, Mindanao's fiscal autonomy and monitoring, Colombia's reintegration and transitional justice, Sierra Leone's truth-plus-accountability — adapted to an entrenched, sanctuary-supported insurgency within a nuclear-armed federal state.

12. District Prioritisation: Where the Roadmap Begins

The monograph classifies KP's 40 districts into four security tiers. Implementation should follow the tiers, not a uniform provincial rollout.

Tier	Districts	Priority interventions (first 24–60 months)
1 — Severe, sustained insurgency	North Waziristan, South Waziristan, Bannu, Lakki Marwat	Police protection package; military–police intelligence fusion; displaced-return and compensation completion; school and health reconstruction; counter-drone systems; district courts
2 — High and episodic	Khyber (Tirah), Bajaur, Mohmand, Kurram, Orakzai, D.I. Khan, Tank, Karak, Hangu	NMD policing framework; Kurram accord enforcement and disarmament milestones; Tirah return and compensation; sectarian de-escalation; road security
3 — Urban/soft-target belt	Peshawar, Mardan, Charsadda, Nowshera, Swat, Shangla	Counter-terrorism policing; soft-target protection (markets, mosques, schools, transport); Swat re-entry strategy; Safe City deployment with data-protection safeguards
4 — Strategic exposure	Abbottabad, Mansehra, Haripur, Chitral, Dir, Malakand	Infrastructure and CPEC-corridor protection; tourism-route security; GLOF and climate resilience; border-adjacent monitoring

A geographic security map is described in Appendix H of the monograph (district tiers, the southern insurgency core, the western border arc, and the urban quadrilateral), and should be read alongside this table.

13. Monitoring Indicator Set

Domain	Indicator	Target by 2035
Violence	Conflict fatalities (province; by district)	≤ 400/year
Parallel governance	Districts with sustained TTP taxation/justice	Zero for four consecutive quarters
Police	Personnel killed per year	≤ 50
Policing	Attacks survived without loss; responders equipped	≥ 80%
Justice	ATC cases concluded within 24 months	≥ 75%
Detention	Persons held without charge	Published count; statutory limits enforced
Fiscal	Merged-district transfer released within fiscal year	≥ 95%; audit published
Local government	NMD councils elected with budgets	All seven districts
Education	NMD girls' secondary enrolment	Within 10 points of provincial average
Economy	Merged-district poverty gap	≤ 10 percentage points
Politics	Proscriptions of non-violent parties	Zero

Domain	Indicator	Target by 2035
Reporting	Annual Normalization Report tabled	Within 180 days each year

14. Bottom Line

The state has spent two decades and hundreds of billions of rupees on a counter-insurgency that has repeatedly suppressed the insurgency without normalizing the province. The evidence assembled in the accompanying monograph shows that the missing elements are not operational: they are the **fiscal settlement of the merged districts, the protection of the police who fight, the courts that convert force into law, the local institutions that give the state a face, and the political space that gives grievance a lawful destination**. These are commitments the state can make without any adversary's consent. On the arithmetic of this study, they are also cheaper — by a factor of two to four — than the conflict they would begin to end.

Prepared from the monograph "Normalizing the Security Situation of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa: Conflict Evolution, Threat Dynamics, and Pathways to Sustainable Peace." All figures attributed to their sources in the monograph; contested claims flagged as contested.